Election Day Will Have Extra Watchers This Year

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When Americans vote in the **midterm elections** on November 3, extra watchers will be on duty at many **polling places**. The U.S. Department of Justice, or DOJ, plans to send about 1,000 **election monitors** to all 50 states on Election Day more than double the number used in the 2022 midterms.

Election monitors have a quiet job. They stand back, watch how voting is run, and report what they see. Their purpose is to make sure **voting-rights laws** are followed, so that nobody is wrongly turned away or scared off from casting a **ballot**. "They're there to just do as their name suggests, which is to observe," said Stacey Young, a former DOJ lawyer who has been a monitor three times. Monitors never run the voting itself, and the department says its staff have been told clearly not to interfere. If a problem needs enforcement, that would happen after the election.

So why are some state officials concerned this year? One reason is the size of the effort. David Becker, a former DOJ voting-rights attorney, called the scale "not normal," but added that he is "not particularly concerned." He noted that monitors have no blanket authority to be everywhere and must follow state and local rules about entering **polling places**. Another change is that **prosecutors** will be allowed to serve as monitors this year, ending a long-standing rule against it. Young said **prosecutors** can look like a more intimidating presence. A senior DOJ official defended the plan, saying monitors will focus on busy areas and on places that have had problems with language or disability access and argued that it is the critics warning about monitors who might really frighten voters.

The monitors will visit only Election Day **polling places**, not early-voting sites.

Word Treasure

midterm elections -- Elections held in the middle of a president's four-year term, when voters choose members of Congress and other officials.

polling places -- The places, such as schools or community halls, where people go in person to cast their votes.

election monitors -- Officials sent to watch how voting is run and report what they see, without running the voting themselves.

voting-rights laws -- Laws that protect every eligible citizen's right to vote and be treated fairly at the polls.

ballot -- The paper form or screen a voter uses to record their choices in an election.

prosecutors -- Government lawyers whose job is to bring criminal cases against accused people in court.

Background you need

In the United States, states and local officials run elections, and voters cast their ballots at polling places on Election Day or at early-voting sites beforehand.

Federal voting-rights laws protect every eligible citizen's right to vote, and the Department of Justice is the part of the federal government responsible for enforcing those laws.

Election monitors are observers the department sends to watch how voting is run and report what they see; they never run the voting itself and are told not to interfere.

Monitors must follow state and local rules about entering polling places, so their work is meant to stay quiet and behind the scenes.

Break it down

LEAD: About 1,000 Justice Department election monitors will watch polling places in all 50 states on November 3

KEY EVENT: The DOJ is sending more than double the number of monitors used in the 2022 midterms

+- WHO: Department of Justice staff, with prosecutors allowed to serve as monitors this year

+- WHEN: Election Day, November 3, at Election Day polling places only

EVIDENCE: Monitors observe and report but never run voting or interfere; any enforcement would happen after the election

OPEN QUESTION: Will the bigger monitoring presence reassure voters or frighten some of them away?

Why it matters

Elections only work if every eligible voter can cast a ballot freely and trust the result. How the federal government watches voting, and how that presence makes voters feel, shapes confidence in the whole system.

Test what you remember

1. How many election monitors does the Department of Justice plan to send on Election Day?

- (A) More than 10,000
- (B) About 500
- (C) About 1,000
- (D) About 100

2. What is an election monitor's main job?

- (A) To decide who is allowed to vote
- (B) To run the voting at polling places
- (C) To observe how voting is run and report what they see
- (D) To count the ballots after polls close

3. How does this year's number of monitors compare with the 2022 midterms?

- (A) More than double
- (B) Slightly fewer
- (C) About the same
- (D) Half as many

4. What is new about who may serve as a monitor this year?

- (A) Prosecutors will be allowed to serve as monitors
- (B) Former lawyers are no longer allowed to serve
- (C) State officials may serve for the first time
- (D) Monitors may help run the voting

5. What did David Becker say about the scale of this year's effort?

- (A) He called it "not normal" but said he is "not particularly concerned"
- (B) He said monitors should be banned from polling places
- (C) He said it is completely normal
- (D) He said it should be even bigger

6. Which places will the monitors NOT visit?

- (A) Busy polling places
- (B) Polling places in the 50 states
- (C) Early-voting sites
- (D) Places that have had language-access problems

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: A 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Stacey Young, a former DOJ lawyer who has been a monitor three times: She says monitors are there simply to observe, as their name suggests.

2. David Becker, a former DOJ voting-rights attorney: He called the scale of this year's effort "not normal" but said he is not particularly concerned, noting that monitors have no blanket authority and must follow state and local rules.

3. A senior DOJ official: The official defended the plan, saying monitors will focus on busy areas and places that have had problems with language or disability access, and argued that critics warning about monitors might really frighten voters.

4. Some state officials: They are concerned about the size of the effort and the worry that monitors, especially prosecutors, could look intimidating to voters.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):